How to Drive Your Favorite Car for a Long Time

What should I do?

"I'll teach you everything," the veteran said with a laugh as he lit his cigarette. We asked Kazuo Sakiyama about 10 car maintenance techniques to extend the lifespan. When I told him, "I want to keep driving the car I bought for life!"

photo: Kazufumi Shimoyashiki illustration: Telly Sahara edit: Kyosuke Nitta

Although more than 20 years have passed since their release, "A Book That Won't Break Down Even After 100,000 Kilometers" and "The Lifespan of Cars Keeps Increasing!!" (both published by Sansuisha and Kodansha) continue to be textbooks for car enthusiasts. The author, Kazuo Sakiyama, is a maintenance expert with a 60-year career. If you want to learn the secrets to keeping a car in healthy condition, he is the only person to ask!

Q1. What is the most important thing to do first to make a car last longer?

A It is often said that modern cars don't break down, while old cars are prone to breaking. But the truth is, you have to accept that cars do break down. The model year doesn't matter; there is no such thing as a maintenance-free vehicle in the world. Also, I want to emphasize loudly that just because a car passes inspection doesn't mean it's fine! Vehicle inspections only confirm the temporary safety of the car on the day of the test; they do not guarantee safety for the following two years. If an accident occurs due to poor maintenance, it is not the inspector's fault but the owner's responsibility. That said, cars don't suddenly break down out of nowhere. If there is a problem, the car will always give signs through sounds or smells. To notice these signs, warming up the engine is very important. Many people start driving immediately after starting the engine, but that is not good. Listen carefully to the sounds during idling. Suddenly accelerating puts a strain on the engine, so the rule is to drive at about 30 km/h until around the second traffic light. Don't play music; listen to the car's voice and learn to recognize both when it is running perfectly and when it is not. For this reason, it is important for owners to constantly sharpen their five senses.

When suddenly woken up and told to run immediately, cars can also suffer from poor condition. Consider warm-up driving as a warming-up for the car. Think of it as a warming-up for the car.

Q2. Are there any good things to do on a daily basis?

A Make a habit of performing a 30-second visual inspection without feeling bothered. First, walk around the car and check the tires. How is the tread wear? Is the air pressure keeping a certain healthy condition? Are there any cracks on the sidewalls? Then, once seated in the driver's seat, turn on the hazard lights and press the brake pedal several times to check if the blinking is functioning properly. Since it's difficult to check all four corners alone, placing mirrors or reflectors in front of and behind the parking spot makes it easier.

The depth of the tire tread. When it falls below 1.6 mm, the legal usage limit slip sign appears. Scratches and cracks on the sidewall can cause bursts, so be very careful. Both overinflation and underinflation of air pressure are bad. Know the best condition.

Q3. What should be done regularly?

A There are people who have never opened the hood, but you should at least check the engine compartment once a week. If the coolant level is extremely low or the fan belt is about to break, driving without knowing this will directly lead to overheating and cause serious damage to the engine. Therefore, you should keep track of the oil and fluid levels. Routine inspections are very simple. Brake fluid, coolant, windshield washer fluid, and battery fluid—these four can be checked by looking at the appropriate level lines on their tanks to see how much has decreased. For engine oil, use the stick-shaped oil level gauge.

Just pull it out and check. Besides that,

You can tell if there are signs of oil or water leaks by looking around. You can check if the fan belt is loose with your bare hands. You can check if the fan belt is loose with your bare hands.

For checking the engine oil level gauge, having a white cloth (rag) is convenient. Pull it out and quickly wipe the oil off the tip, then reinsert it and pull it out again to check the oil level.

Q4. What should you do when you notice your car is not running well?

A If any of the indicator lights lined up on the meter panel are flashing, you must not ignore it. Those are warning lights and carry important messages from the car. The urgency varies by color: yellow means caution and red indicates a serious problem that is critical. Therefore, the first thing is to understand the meaning of the warning lights. Also, pay close attention to any subtle feelings of "something is off" that only you can notice. It's helpful to note down on your smartphone the timeline and context of the issue, as well as any smells or sounds, so you can clearly communicate them to the mechanic.

It is ideal to prevent problems before warning lights appear. Therefore, you should develop the habit of checking the engine room. If you frequently check the engine oil level, the oil pressure warning light will not suddenly flash.

Q5. To take care of the car's body What should I do?

A The cars I took care of commonly had mileage of 200,000 km or 300,000 km. I wasn't doing anything particularly special, but I was thorough about two things: using engine oil suitable for the engine and changing the oil frequently without skimping. Oil acts as the car's blood, providing lubrication, cooling, and cleaning functions, greatly affecting fuel efficiency and smooth acceleration. By checking the oil's dirtiness and level, you can also gauge the engine's health. There are many manufacturers and viscosity numbers like "15W-40" can be confusing at first, so how do you choose? Since it requires some knowledge, until you can judge for yourself, it's best to follow the advice of your trusted maintenance shop.

Unpleasant odors are more serious than sounds. The danger lev
If the smell of gasoline fills the interior,
there is a risk of fire.
Stop the car and call a mechanic for advice.

Recommended is "MOTUL." It contains low sulfur content. It is hard to oxidize and has a high cleaning effect, allowing it to rotate smoothly. By the way, if the engine oil filter is dirty, even new oil will have its effectiveness halved, so at the very least, the filter I want you to replace the filter every other time you perform an exchange.

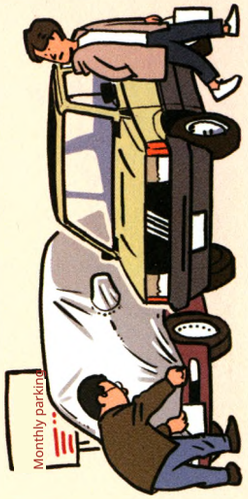
Q6. When is the right time to replace consumables?

A They should be replaced sharply at about 80% before being completely used up. For example, brake pads. Some people ignore the squeaking noise, thinking, "The vehicle passed inspection, and there is still some pad left, so it should be fine," but that's never good. Aged brake pads are unusable, and the wear depends on how you press the brakes, so it's better not to rely too much on the replacement guidelines. The mindset of "it can still go" can sometimes be fatal. The timing belt, which is also the lifeline of the engine, is the same. Its average lifespan is said to be 10 years or 1 million kilometers, but this also varies depending on driving habits. Rubber and plastic consumable parts should be replaced decisively when the timing is right.

The brake pads make a scraping sound when the metal plate rubs after exceeding the limit. The timing belt squeaks. Make it a habit to note the date when consumables are replaced.

Q7. Is a cover necessary to protect the car when parking in an uncovered parking lot?

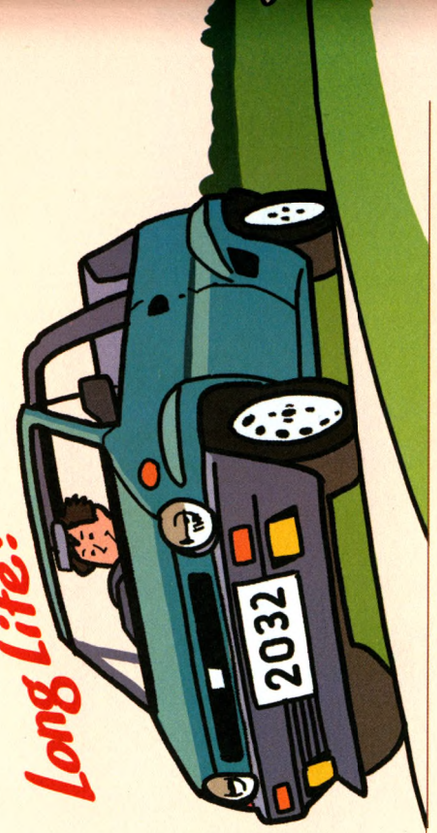
A Although body covers are said to be necessary for keeping a car looking good for a long time, to be honest, they are counterproductive. The reason is that sand and dust blown in from the hem, combined with the cover fluttering in the wind, cause friction. Because it scratches the vehicle body. It's also not good to cover it immediately after returning from outside. You have to remove the dust first. It's effective for theft prevention during long-term storage, though.



Recently, it seems that there are more covers that fit tightly without gaps, but there is no cover that protects the suspension area. In unpaved parking lots, from the ground Moisture rises and accumulates inside the cover, which can cause rust.

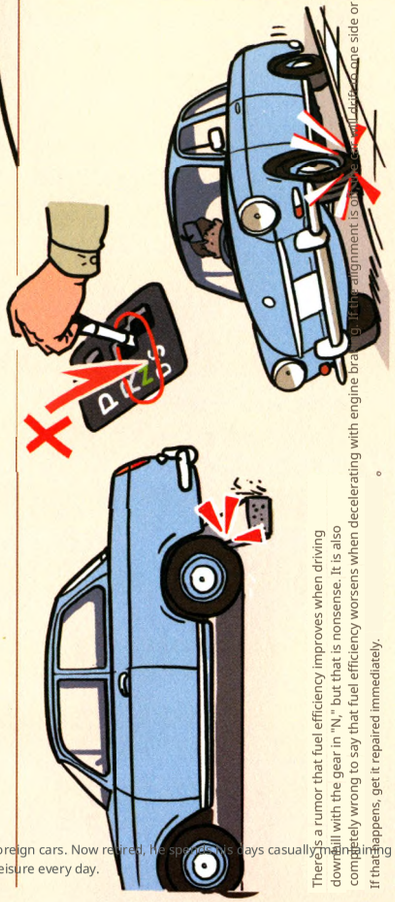
Q8. What kind of driving should you avoid to make your car last longer?

A Needless to say, avoid sudden starts, rapid acceleration, sudden braking, and sharp turns—any driving with "sudden" actions. Therefore, the principles are "don't panic," "don't rush," and "be cautious and careful." Unless it's for racing, flooring the accelerator is out of the question. It's also unacceptable to speed on rough roads if the vehicle is not designed for off-road use. It is essential to drive appropriately, understanding the basic design and characteristics of the car. Also, some people shift from Drive mode to "N" or "P" at every traffic light, but it's best to stop doing that immediately. For automatic transmission vehicles, each time this is done, the clutch plates wear out, the AT fluid (lubricant) deteriorates, and nothing good comes of it for the transmission. When stuck in traffic jams on the highway and unable to move for a while, it's safe to shift to "P," but normally, you should not change gears. Regarding tires, if you park with the tires pressed against a stopper for a week or a long period, pressure concentrates in one spot, which can deform the tires. Therefore, I want you to develop the habit of parking just a little away from the wheel stopper. Also, when you enter a curb or a step at an angle and try to forcefully climb over it, causing the car to jerk, right? That is also an act that disrupts the alignment, which is the arrangement of the wheels. Similarly, When parking in a garage, sometimes you turn the steering wheel to the limit where it "won't turn any further" (called "full lock"), but this can also negatively affect the alignment and put a lot of stress on the suspension. Doing these driving actions a few times won't shorten the car's lifespan, but if you keep doing them for 5 or 10 years, the car will eventually cry out. So, you should try to avoid them as much as possible. Also, just like people, cars stay healthier when they are constantly in motion. If you rest, your physical strength declines, right? Regularly driving the car is the best secret to longevity.



Person who provided the [redacted] Kazuo Sakiyama Mechanic

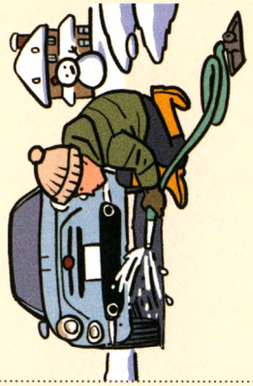
Kazuo Sakiyama | Born in 1943 in Shinagawa Ward, Tokyo. At the young age of 18, he joined "Jack's Garage," a pioneering maintenance shop in Akasaka, and in 1971 established "Sakiyama Automobile Service." Until closing the workshop at the end of 2020, he handled over 600 customer vehicles annually and became nationally renowned as "Sakiyama" when it came to foreign cars. Now retired, he spends his days casually [redacted] the vehicle [redacted] Cup," a racing event [redacted] participated in for [redacted] He maintains the "FIAT SPORT 850" used in the Abarth Cup at his leisure every day.



There is a rumor that fuel efficiency improves when driving downhill with the gear in "N," but that is nonsense. It is also completely wrong to say that fuel efficiency worsens when decelerating with engine braking. Alignment is [redacted] side or the other when you take your hands off the wheel while driving. If that happens, get it repaired immediately.

Q9. After winter ends, the area around the tires starts to rust...

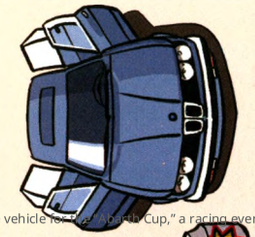
A Did you drive on snowy roads? The cause is salt damage. You might think, "But I'm not near the sea?" However, the main ingredient of the de-icing agents spread on roads to melt snow is calcium chloride. If it gets kicked up by the tires and stays there, it causes rust due to salt damage. Therefore, if you drive on snowy roads, wash the undercarriage with fresh water on the same day. Use a hose to thoroughly clean every detail.



No matter how cold it is, wash the car immediately after driving on snowy roads. Spray water from various angles onto the tires and the entire undercarriage. Do the same and wash it off after being exposed to sea breeze for a long time.

Q10. Keeping the interior comfortable Things you should do What are the good practices?

A If you don't clean the inside of the car, bacteria will continue to increase, and the seats and floor mats will be full of dust mites. The closed interior during the humid rainy season is an ideal environment for mold to grow, so on sunny days, open all the doors to air it out. Throw away trash and spray disinfectant to dramatically improve the environment. Polishing the body is important, but keeping the interior equally clean is also essential.



Air drying for about 3 hours is sufficient. ~ In May and July, it's good to place about three moisture absorbers like these inside the car. Use insect repellent paper for clothing. Locking it is also effective.